

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, JUNE 8, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Plastic surgeon case to be audited

Illinois regulators seek changes in law after Tribune investigation

By Gregory Royal Pratt and Christy Gutowski
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois' medical licensing agency said it will perform an internal review of how it handled allegations against Chicago plastic surgeon Dr. Ayoub Sayeg after a Tribune investigation found the state has yet to discipline him despite eight patient

deaths.

The Illinois Department of Financial and Professional Regulation also said it plans to pursue changes to state laws to help accelerate the disciplinary process in similar cases. The agency has been investigating Sayeg since 2020, and at least three patients have died while that process was pending, the Tribune reported.

The department announced the measures in a statement sent to the Tribune before the newspaper published its investigation Sunday. Eight of Sayeg's patients — all of

them women of color — died in a seven-year span shortly after their surgeries at his 63 Laser & Skin Clinic, located in a predominantly Latino neighborhood on the city's Southwest Side, the Tribune found. Each surgery involved a tummy tuck and at least one other procedure, typically liposuction.

Six of the women died from complications of plastic surgery, according to medical examiner and coroner records, and two other patients overdosed on pain medication at home after undergoing their procedures. The Tribune could

identify only one other doctor in Cook County who, since 2015, had more than one patient die after performing plastic surgery. He had two patient deaths, records show.

The Department of Financial and Professional Regulation, which licenses physicians and many other professionals, confirmed it initiated formal administrative proceedings against Sayeg after receiving a complaint in 2020 regarding Idalia Corcoles, a 39-year-old Chicago mother of four who died the previous year, shortly after undergoing surgery.

But more than five years later, Sayeg still has a clean medical license.

"IDFPR acknowledges that the timeline of this case has fallen short of our standards, and it has initiated a comprehensive internal audit to gather a complete understanding of the situation and to prevent similar scenarios in the future," the department wrote in its statement. "This is a serious matter, and the Department remains wholly focused on pursuing the maximum penalty

See **SURGEON** on Page A2

Invention lowers lead in school fountains

But can CPS engineer's device be scaled for use in a citywide crisis?

By Christiana Freitag
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Late at night in 2016, Michael Ramos sat hunched over his dining room table in his Harwood Heights condominium, assembling valves and motor parts he'd picked up from local electronics shops.

By day, he worked as a building engineer at Von Steuben Metropolitan Science Center high school in Chicago. By night, he tried to solve a problem he feared was putting students, and his own children, at risk: toxic lead in drinking water.

Ramos attended evening classes to become a home inspector and spent months tinkering on a palm-sized invention he believed could solve the lead contamination of the school's water fountains. Several had tested above the Illinois Department of Public Health's 5 parts per billion threshold, according to Chicago Public Schools.

Today, dozens of his devices have been installed in city and suburban schools, as well as in residences, but the city's lead contamination problem is huge.

"Families and children are being exposed every day, and they don't even know it because you can't see it, you can't smell it, you can't taste it," said Ramos, who has three children. "But it's there."

Chicago has the most lead lines in the nation, an infrastructure challenge that will take decades to address. In buildings and homes constructed before 1986, the year lead pipes were banned, contamination remains an invisible risk, including inside many of Chicago's public schools.

Children are especially vulnerable to lead exposure, which can harm early brain development and lead to lifelong cognitive and behavioral issues. There is no safe level of lead exposure, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and recent studies have found at least two-thirds of children under the age of 6 have been exposed to lead-contaminated water in Chicago.

For Ramos, he said he hadn't paid much attention to Chicago's water issue until the crisis in Flint, Michigan.

"(Flint) opened up the nation to the idea that we do have major water quality issues," Ramos said. "As a father, I'm like, 'Wow, well now you have my full attention.'"

In 2014, the city of Flint switched its water supply from Lake Huron to the Flint River to save money, causing distribution pipes to corrode and leach lead and other contaminants into municipal drinking water. Two years later, a state of emergency was declared, and Flint residents were told not to drink their tap water — but the damage was already done. Roughly one-quarter of children in Flint have tested for elevated levels of lead since the crisis, according to a 2022 Cornell University report.

See **LEAD** on Page A6



Leo Diaz pays for parking at a Park Chicago box on West Fulton Street in the West Loop on May 27. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A shot to fix Chicago's parking meter deal?

Aldermen test chances to rework longstanding agreement amid sale

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As aldermen weigh a long-shot chance of reworking Chicago's infamous parking meter deal, some are citing one firm point.

"The worst-case scenario is the status quo," Ald. Walter "Red" Burnett, 27th, said.

But they are hoping to do better than that.

Several council members are attempting to find ways to force Stonepeak Partners, a New York investment firm aiming to buy the much-loathed lease from

Chicago Parking Meters LLC, to at least tweak the terms. Chicago drivers who are looking at decades of ever-increasing parking rates — with the money continuing to go into the pockets of a private company rather than the city's coffers — would cheer any change in their favor.

Among the possible leverage points some are considering is a clause in the meter deal that allows the council to consider "the background and reputation" of the proposed operator. Stonepeak, aldermen have noted, owns an air freight company with a subsid-

iary that carries out deportation flights for U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. That background puts the company starkly at odds, they argue, with policies and values in Chicago that seek to oppose ICE activities.

Aldermen are planning to consider their options in a public hearing and are in the process of retaining legal and financial advisers to determine what, if anything, they could score.

The notorious 2008 privatization scheme, masterminded by then-Mayor Richard M. Daley and rushed through the City Council

in three days, sold a 75-year lease for a \$1.15 billion cash payout. Aldermen at the time voted 40-5 to approve the deal.

That lump sum pales in comparison with what the lease has already made for the parking system's private owners, led by Morgan Stanley, alongside Deeside Investments, a firm reportedly nearly half owned by the Abu Dhabi Investment Authority. According to an audit published in April, it earned a record \$189 million in revenue

See **METERS** on Page A4

STACEY KING
1967-2026

He 'loved being a Bull'

Stacey King, a three-time NBA champion during the first half of the 1990's Bulls dynasty and longtime broadcaster, died Sunday at the age of 59, the team announced in a statement. King was a beloved member of the organization who provided color commentary for the team's local broadcast affiliate for the last two decades. "He had a unique gift for bringing people together and making every game feel personal," said Bulls CEO Michael Reinsdorf. **Chicago Sports**



Stacey King, left, laughs alongside Adam Amin, right, before the first half of the Bulls game against the Pistons at United Center on Dec. 30, 2022. MICHAEL BLACKSHIRE/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Israel: Iran has broken ceasefire

Israel said Sunday that Iran has launched missiles at it in the first such bombardment since a fragile ceasefire took effect in early April, complicating mediation efforts for a deal to end the war. **Nation & World**

Relaxed vibes at Chicago Blues Fest

The mostly easy-going tunes, a warm early summer evening, and the flotilla of lawn chairs and blankets on Millennium Park's Great Lawn gave the annual music celebration a chill atmosphere. **Arts & Living**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 84 L: 71
TUE. H: 89 L: 74
WED. H: 94 L: 76
Complete details on Page A14

INDEX

Almanac A10
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A5
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A10
Television B7

178th year No. 159
© Chicago Tribune



7 49485 00001 2